



Ferrets are small, domesticated carnivorous mammals belonging to the weasel family (*Mustelidae*). Known for their long, slender bodies and mischievous "bandit" faces, they have been companions to humans for over 2,500 years. Their name appropriately comes from the Latin word *furittus*, meaning "little thief," a nod to their instinctual habit of stealing and hoarding small household items.

Core Biological Facts

- **Family & Relatives:** They are closely related to otters, badgers, and wolverines. They are not rodents, despite common misconceptions.
- **Lifespan:** Domestic ferrets typically live between 5 and 10 years.
- **Activity Patterns:** They are crepuscular, meaning they are naturally most active during dawn and dusk, though they often adapt to their owner's schedule.
- **Sleep:** Ferrets are champion sleepers, often snoozing for 18 to 20 hours a day. They can sometimes enter a "dead sleep" so deep that they appear unresponsive, which can be alarming to new owners.